Caves d'Affinage d'Épagny SC · Cooperative Ripening Cellars

ALPAGE SHELF PERMIT: GUIDE FOR APPLICANTS, 2027 SUMMER SEASON

Chemin des Caves 11, 1664 Épagny (Gruyères), Canton of Fribourg · Issued 28 September 2026 · Valid for wheels made between 1 June and 30 September 2027

Ref.: CAE-ASP-2027
Application form: ASP-A
Release form: ASP-R
Version: 4

PERMIT AT A GLANCE

Application window	1 February to 15 April 2027 (form ASP-A, by post or at the cellar office)
Allocation letters sent	by 14 May 2027
First and last delivery day	15 June 2027 to 9 October 2027
Delivery hours	Tuesday and Friday, 06:30 to 10:30, loading bay 2
Minimum ripening before release	5 months from the date of manufacture
Final collection date	31 May 2028

1. PURPOSE OF THE PERMIT

Caves d'Affinage d'Épagny SC is a cooperative that ripens hard mountain cheese for its member dairies in the Gruyère district. Each summer it rents a limited number of spruce shelf boards to small alpage producers who make cheese in mountain huts on the pastures around Moléson, Charmey and the Vallée du Motélon and who have no cellar of their own that stays cool and humid enough for long ripening. The Alpage Shelf Permit gives the holder the right to store a fixed number of wheels in the cooperative's cellars for one season, with turning and rind care done by cellar staff.

The permit is issued and signed by **Séverine Pasquier**, Managing Director. Shelf allocation, acceptance of wheels at delivery and release decisions are the responsibility of **Grégoire Bapst**, Maître Affineur (cellar master). Hygiene, sampling and pest control are handled by **Nadine Murith**, Hygiene and Quality Officer.

2. WHO MAY APPLY

Applicants must run a summer alpage dairy in the Canton of Fribourg or the Pays-d'Enhaut (Vaud) and hold a valid dairy hygiene registration for the 2027 summer. Each applicant may hold one permit, for between 6 and 60 wheels.

The following documents must be attached to form ASP-A:

□ A copy of the 2027 dairy hygiene registration for the alpage hut, with its registration number.
□ The producer's casein mark number, which must appear on every wheel.
□ A milk quality report from an accredited laboratory dated no earlier than 1 January 2027.
□ Proof of liability insurance of at least CHF 2 million covering goods stored at third-party premises.

If more boards are requested than are free, places go first to producers who held a 2026 permit without a written warning, then to producers whose alpage lies within 15 km of Épagny, then by lot drawn on 30 April 2027 at the cellar office.

3. ACCEPTANCE OF WHEELS AT DELIVERY

Wheels must be delivered after brining and after at least 48 hours of drying at the alpage. Each wheel is weighed on arrival on the calibrated scale at loading bay 2, and its fresh weight m_0 is recorded on the delivery note. Wheels below 6 kg or above 42 kg are not accepted. The producer must state the

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brining time for every batch; the minimum brining time depends on the fresh weight and is set by equation (1).

$$t_b \geq 0.68 \times m_0 \quad \textbf{(1)}$$

where t_b is the time the wheel spent in the brine bath (hours) and m_0 the fresh weight of the wheel at delivery (kg). The brine must have a salt content of 20 to 23 % and a temperature of 12 to 14 °C. Wheels lighter than 12 kg need at least 10 hours of brining, whatever equation (1) gives.

Worked example: a wheel delivered at m_0 = 32 kg needs $t_b \geq 0.68 \times 32 = 21.76$ hours, so a batch brined for 22 hours is accepted, while a batch brined for 20 hours is refused.

Wheels with a cracked rind, an unreadable casein mark or early blowing (a domed face) are also refused and must be taken back the same day.

4. SHELF BOARDS AND PERMIT FEE

Each spruce board holds two wheels side by side, and boards are allocated whole, so an odd number of wheels takes up one half-empty board. The permit holder chooses one of the two cellars on form ASP-A:

- **Cave Basse** (lower cellar, 13 °C, 94 to 96 % relative humidity): wheels are turned and brushed twice a week. Care charge CHF 2.60 per wheel per month.
- **Cave Haute** (upper cellar, 15 °C, 90 to 92 % relative humidity): wheels are turned and brushed once a week. Care charge CHF 1.90 per wheel per month.

The permit fee covers board rent and care for the whole stay and is set by equation (2).

$$F = F_0 + M \times \left(p \times \left\lceil \frac{n}{2} \right\rceil + c \times n \right) \quad \textbf{(2)}$$

where F is the permit fee (CHF), F_0 the application fee of CHF 120 (CHF 95 for the 2026 season), M the number of months the wheels are in the cellar (any started calendar month counts as a full month), p the board rent of CHF 4.20 per board per month (CHF 3.80 until 31 December 2026), n the number of wheels on the permit, $\lceil n/2 \rceil$ the number of boards (n divided by 2, rounded up), and c the care charge for the chosen cellar.

Worked example: 15 wheels in Cave Basse for 7 months use $\lceil 15/2 \rceil = 8$ boards. F = 120 + 7 × (4.20 × 8 + 2.60 × 15) = 120 + 7 × (33.60 + 39.00) = 120 + 508.20 = **CHF 628.20**.

A deposit of 30 % of the estimated fee is due within 20 days of the allocation letter; the balance is invoiced when the last wheel leaves the cellar and is payable within 30 days.

5. EXPECTED WEIGHT AT RELEASE

Wheels lose water during ripening. As a basis for the shortfall compensation in section 6, the expected weight of each wheel at release is set by equation (3).

$$m_t = m_0 \times (1 - \lambda)^{t} \quad \textbf{(3)}$$

where m_t is the expected weight at release (kg), m_0 the fresh weight recorded at delivery (kg), t the ripening time in the cellar in whole months, and λ the monthly weight-loss rate of the cellar: 0.0085 in Cave Basse and 0.0120 in Cave Haute. Results are rounded to two decimals.

Worked example: a 32 kg wheel ripened for 8 months has an expected weight of $32 \times (1 - 0.0085)^8 = 29.89$ kg in Cave Basse, but only $32 \times (1 - 0.0120)^8 = 29.05$ kg in Cave Haute.

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6. SHORTFALL COMPENSATION

If wheels lose much more weight than expected, the cooperative pays compensation. A loss of up to 3 % below the expected weight is normal variation and is not compensated. Compensation for a batch of wheels released on the same day is calculated with equation (4).

$$K = r \times n \times \max\left(0, 0.97 \times m_t - \bar{m}\right) \qquad (4)$$

where K is the compensation (CHF), r the compensation rate of CHF 16.80 per kg, n the number of wheels in the batch, m_t the expected weight at release from equation (3) (kg), and $\bar{m}$ the mean measured weight of the wheels in the batch on the release scale (kg).

Worked example: 10 wheels of 32 kg ripened for 8 months in Cave Basse have m_t = 29.89 kg, so the threshold is 0.97 × 29.89 = 28.99 kg. If their mean release weight is 28.40 kg, K = 16.80 × 10 × (28.99 − 28.40) = 16.80 × 10 × 0.59 = **CHF 99.12**, credited against the balance invoice.

Exclusions. No compensation is paid for wheels with rind damage recorded at delivery, for wheels collected late (section 8), or for wheels released at the producer's request before the minimum ripening of 5 months. Claims must be made on form ASP-R on the release day; claims made later are not considered.

7. HYGIENE, INSPECTIONS AND CHEESE MITES

Permit holders may visit their wheels on Wednesdays from 14:00 to 16:30, accompanied by a member of the cellar staff.

The cooperative takes a rind and core sample from one wheel in every twenty (at least one per permit) during the third month of ripening.

Cheese mites and mould. Any producer who notices cheese mites, a powdery brown dust on the rind, or unusual mould on any wheel during a visit must report it on the same day to the Hygiene and Quality Officer, Nadine Murith (direct line 026 912 47 36), and not to the cellar staff on duty. She decides whether boards are cleaned, wheels are brushed or the affected rack is closed. Wheels on a closed rack are not charged care fees for the months the rack is closed.

8. RELEASE AND COLLECTION

1. Book a release date at least 10 days in advance with the cellar office; releases take place on Mondays and Thursdays from 07:00 to 11:00.
2. The cellar master checks that each wheel has ripened at least 5 months from its date of manufacture and records its release weight on form ASP-R.
3. Pay any open invoices; wheels are not released while a previous invoice is more than 30 days overdue.

Wheels still in the cellar after 31 May 2028 are charged a late storage fee of CHF 1.50 per wheel per day.

9. BREACHES AND WITHDRAWAL

A written warning is given for a delivery outside delivery hours, an unannounced visit, or missing paperwork for a batch. A second warning in the same season ends the permit, and all wheels must be collected within 14 days, whatever their age. A producer who withdraws in writing before 15 June 2027 receives a refund of the deposit less the application fee; later withdrawals are not refunded.

Declaration. I have read this guide (CAE-ASP-2027, version 4) and agree to its conditions.

Producer: name, casein mark and signature	Séverine Pasquier, Managing Director	Date

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